

## Chapter 46-2: Laughter

The Red Spider Lilies grew on the other shore of the River of Forgetting, which was the other end of the Bridge of Helplessness. No ghost dared approach this place. Therefore, as far as the eye could see, there were blood-red flowers everywhere, rootless and leafless, growing in brownish-red soil.

Two brick paths were embedded in the flower clusters. Meng Po walked carefully, saying as she went: "Though these Red Spider Lilies are flowers, they are actually formed from the souls of people whose obsessions haven't dissipated. Their petals are like knives - anyone with emotions who touches them will feel pain like being burned."

"However, Divine Venerable surely has nothing to fear from these flowers." Meng Po said with a smile. She stood in the center of the flower cluster, and when she looked up, countless flower stems stood quietly, unmoving even in the wind, giving one a sense of tranquility.

Ning Fuyi was initially confused, but then remembered that Chu Qingqiu cultivated the Heartless Way, and understood.

Chu Qingqiu said nothing.

"But I've already examined them countless times and found no problems with the Red Spider Lilies. Perhaps it's because I'm just a lowly ghost officer with little magical power." Meng Po said.

"If I use immortal power here, can you keep those ghosts from surging over?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"They won't be able to cross the Bridge of Helplessness for a while, but it absolutely can't be too long. External energy will cause the underworld's yin energy to fluctuate. These souls awaiting reincarnation are still manageable, but if we attract the fierce ghosts wandering outside the Yellow Springs, I won't be able to bear that responsibility." Meng Po answered fearfully.

Chu Qingqiu nodded, then suddenly spread her arms wide. Countless feather-shaped lights appeared around her body, blown by the wind toward the flower clusters covering the mountains and fields.

She seemed to be able to place her divine consciousness in these points of light. Ning Fuyi obediently crouched on her shoulder, marveling inwardly.

Even though she had lived through one lifetime already, there were still many things she didn't know as much about as Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu was like a thick heavenly book - one could never guess its contents.

As expected, the ghosts on the Bridge of Helplessness surged and moved, blocked on the bridge by invisible force, pushing and shoving with flailing limbs.

Chu Qingqiu's dark eyebrows suddenly furrowed. She quickly opened her eyes, and those points of light transformed into feathers that floated down, landing in the centers of some flower hearts.

"This..." Meng Po was puzzled.

"Someone has tampered with the Red Spider Lilies." Chu Qingqiu said softly, small ripples stirring in her peach blossom eyes. "Some mixed among them are not Red Spider Lilies, but Eternal Hatred flowers<sup>1</sup>."

"Eternal Hatred?" Meng Po blinked.

"Eternal Hatred!" Ning Fuyi's tail perked up.

Ning Fuyi knew of this thing - it was a flower that grew downstream from the Santu River<sup>2</sup> in the demon realm. This flower was extremely similar to Red Spider Lilies, almost indistinguishable to the naked eye. It required resentful energy as seed and the bone and blood of people filled with resentment as fertilizer to grow even one flower, making it extremely rare even in the demon realm.

Yet the underworld had quietly mixed in so many.

"Is it the demon clan?" Ning Fuyi asked in Chu Qingqiu's ear. Chu Qingqiu hummed in agreement.

Using dew extracted from Eternal Hatred flowers to brew Meng Po Soup - no wonder those ghosts became more resentful after drinking it. If they drank a few more bowls, they'd probably become demon ghosts directly, Ning Fuyi thought to herself.

"I must quickly summon some ghost officers to help me pull out these things. The Reincarnation Well has been blocked for so many days, and recently natural disasters and human calamities have been constant everywhere. If these ghosts still can't enter reincarnation, the underworld won't be able to contain them all!" Learning the culprit, Meng Po's small body ran faster than anyone else's.

She had only run a few steps when she ran back, stuffing a handful of white objects into Chu Qingqiu's hands, saying ingratiatingly: "Thank you for Divine Venerable's assistance. It's just that the underworld is currently short-staffed and can't spare ghost officers to attend to Divine Venerable. Please find a place to settle yourself."

"Turn left on Yellow Springs Road, walk past two embankments and you'll reach Ghost Street<sup>3</sup>. As long as Divine Venerable doesn't expose your immortal power, finding lodging is quite easy. I'll come find you once I solve this matter." Meng Po bowed twice to Chu Qingqiu before running off.

Ning Fuyi looked down at the handful of white objects in Chu Qingqiu's hands and discovered they were actually paper money<sup>4</sup>. She immediately threw back her head and laughed heartily.

Chu Qingqiu's hand stopped in mid-air - she could neither put it away nor throw it away. Finally, she simply closed her eyes and stuffed it all into her sleeve.

"So this matter is settled?" Ning Fuyi said, holding her plump belly.

"We'll know after Meng Po reports back. Though we don't know when or who planted these Eternal Hatred flowers, at least pulling them out can temporarily resolve the underworld's urgent crisis." Chu Qingqiu answered. She turned to leave the Red Spider Lilies, but suddenly hesitated for a moment.

Pressing her chest, she bent down and grasped the nearest Eternal Hatred flower to pull it out. However, when she raised her hand, she accidentally brushed against a nearby Red Spider Lily, and a wound deep enough to see bone suddenly appeared on the back of her hand.

She gasped coldly but didn't pause for a moment, quickly hiding her hand in her sleeve.

Even so, Ning Fuyi still caught sight of her movement clearly. Her eyes rolled, and doubt arose in her heart.

The deeper one's obsessions, the more severe the wound from touching Red Spider Lilies. But didn't Chu Qingqiu cultivate the Heartless Way? She should have no emotions or desires - how could a light touch cause a wound deep enough to see bone?

However, it was obvious Chu Qingqiu didn't want her to see, so she didn't ask further.

Half an hour later, they finally crossed the Bridge of Helplessness again and the embankments Meng Po had mentioned. After walking across another nameless bridge, the view suddenly opened up before them.

Ning Fuyi's mouse eyes widened rarely, and she stood up to look into the distance. She had seen bustling markets in both the mortal and immortal realms, but she truly had never seen the underworld's. Now it seemed it was not inferior to the mortal world at all.

Even because the sky above was pitch black while the streets were full of candlelight, it showed a wonder different from the mortal world.

Not to mention the streets crowded with wrongfully dead ghosts, unjustly dead ghosts, hanged ghosts, and drowned ghosts. Their ethereal figures occasionally bumped into each other, knocking out a few intestines, then bending down to pick them up and stuff them back in.

Quite interesting indeed.

Ning Fuyi found it entertaining, but Chu Qingqiu beneath her feet had gone pale. She suddenly turned her head away, hand pressing her abdomen, looking unwell.

"Divine Venerable seems somewhat unwell. Shall we go down and find a tavern to rest?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"Go if you want to." Chu Qingqiu said, turning her head to reclaim her earlobe from Ning Fuyi's claws. Gripping the white bone, she walked through the muddy ground and stopped in front of a relatively clean Yama Temple<sup>5</sup>, stepping inside.

There were no ghosts in the Yama Temple, only ten giant statues of the Ten Yama Kings standing before them. Several meditation cushions were placed in the center of the temple. Chu Qingqiu sat cross-legged on one, breathing in the temple's incense, finally feeling the churning in her stomach ease somewhat.

"Do you want tea?" Ning Fuyi had already hopped onto the incense altar. Besides fruits, there were also teapots and cups here. When she touched them with her claw, they were still warm.

"If you would." Chu Qingqiu said with pale lips.

She turned to look and saw Ning Fuyi using her round golden hamster body to pick and choose among the fruits above, taking a bite of each. This improper behavior, when performed in her current form, appeared rather comical.

Chu Qingqiu frowned as she watched, and her complexion became less pale.

"Coming."

Ning Fuyi lifted the teapot to pour tea. Though it was somewhat difficult, she managed to fill a cup. However, when setting it down, she didn't hold it steady and her head plunged into the teacup.

She gulped down several mouthfuls of tea, once again cursing that judge in her heart. Of all the things he could have turned her into, why did it have to be a mouse? Though she didn't have to walk herself now, her small body made everything inconvenient.

As she was cursing the judge's ancestors to the eighteenth generation, her tail was suddenly grabbed and she was lifted upside down out of the teacup. A handkerchief scented with gardenia flowers wrapped around her, wiping her up and down.

"Clumsy." Chu Qingqiu's tone was reproachful, yet not entirely so. Her movements were very gentle. Ning Fuyi felt comfortable being petted and lay softly in her palm with puffed cheeks, letting her wipe.

However, as Chu Qingqiu wiped, she got carried away and flipped Ning Fuyi belly-up. Ning Fuyi's stomach felt cold and she suddenly realized something was wrong. Her tail quickly curled up to cover her private areas as she bared her teeth at Chu Qingqiu. But then she froze motionless.

Because, seeing her in this state, Chu Qingqiu's usually ice-cold face suddenly curved into a light, shallow smile!

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## Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **Eternal Hatred flowers (长生恨)**: Flowers from the demon realm that feed on resentment and hatred, used to corrupt the Meng Po Soup

<sup>2</sup> **Santu River (三途川)**: The river that souls cross to reach the afterlife in Japanese Buddhist mythology, referenced here as part of the demon realm

<sup>3</sup> **Ghost Street (鬼街)**: A marketplace in the underworld where ghosts conduct business

<sup>4</sup> **Paper money (纸钱):** Traditional Chinese funeral money burned as offerings to the deceased

<sup>5</sup> **Yama Temple (阎王庙):** A temple dedicated to the Yama Kings, judges of the underworld in Chinese mythology